

AYUSHI CHAUHAN

Boston, MA | ayushi@bu.edu | ayushichauhan1.github.io

SUMMARY

PhD candidate in History at Boston University, specializing in South Asian and environmental history, with research at the intersection of water, disease, development, and governance. My dissertation argues that interventions around water are central to the history of governance, inequality, and development in colonial and postcolonial India, accounting for the tensions between environmental governance and the imagination of shared spaces. I have conducted primary research in archives and libraries across three continents, combining archival methods with GIS spatial analysis.

EDUCATION

Boston University Ph.D. Candidate, History	Boston, MA Expected 2027
Indian Institute of Technology Guwahati M.A., Development Studies	Guwahati, India 2020
Delhi University B.A., History and Political Science	Delhi, India 2018

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Boston University Doctoral Researcher, South Asian Environmental History	Boston, MA September 2021 – Present
• Spearheading a dissertation examining how interventions around water shaped governance, inequality, and development in colonial and postcolonial Indian cities, under the supervision of Dr. Benjamin Siegel. • Passed comprehensive examinations with honors, achieving PhD candidacy, in the following fields: <i>South Asian History — Dr. Benjamin Siegel</i> <i>American and Indian Environmental History — Dr. Sarah Phillips</i> <i>Global Water and Technology Studies — Dr. Caterina Scaramelli</i> <i>Modern China and Transnational Asia — Dr. Rui Hua</i> • Mentored undergraduate students through multiple teaching assistantships. • Co-conceiving and co-organizing a symposium on <i>Asia's Agrarian and Environmental Pasts</i> at Boston University, December 2026.	
Indian Institute of Technology Guwahati Research Assistant to Dr. Arupjyoti Saikia	Guwahati, India 2021
• Assisted with research for <i>The Quest for Modern Assam: A History, 1942–2000</i>.	
Indian Institute of Technology Guwahati — Dept. of Humanities and Social Sciences M.A. Dissertation: <i>Environment and Development: Delhi and Its Impact on the Yamuna River</i>	July 2018 – June 2020

DIGITAL PROJECTS

Railways, City, Environment: A Spatial History of Colonial Delhi, 1857–1931 HISTORICAL GIS	Independent Research Project
• Combines historical GIS, georeferenced colonial maps, and archival sources to trace urban and environmental transformation in Delhi between 1857 and 1931. • Draws on primary sources from the National Archives of India and the British Library India Office Records. • Under embargo pending dissertation submission — available upon request.	

WORK EXPERIENCE

Azim Premji University Research Assistant	Bangalore, India June 2020 – January 2021
• Conducted primary research, including ethnographic fieldwork, for a university-level project on environmental change and its urban impacts. • Collaborated with faculty at Azim Premji University on a study of the commodification of urban commons in India.	

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Graduate Teaching Assistant, Boston University

- Led discussion sections and managed grading and syllabus design.
- Delivered a guest lecture on Health, Sanitation, and Environment in Nineteenth-Century India for HI 234.
- Delivered a guest lecture on Hunger and the Moral Economy for HI 343: Taste, Culture and Power.
- 2025 — HI 343: Taste, Culture and Power: The Global History of Food
- 2024 — HI 234: Introduction to India and South Asia
- 2023 — HI 367: The Odd Couple — China and the USA, 1776 to the Present
- 2022 — HI 384: History of Genocide

PUBLICATIONS

Book Reviews

- *Lively Cities: Reconfiguring Urban Ecology*. *Urban Studies*, January 2024.
- *Revisiting Regulations: Air Pollution and Colonial Urbanism*. *Ecology, Economy, and Society — The INSEE Journal*, 5(1), 235–238, January 2022.

CONFERENCE PAPERS AND PRESENTATIONS

- *Irrigation and Its Evil Effects: Environmental Change and Disease in the Western Yamuna Canal*. Panel: *Unruly Waters: Ecology, Borders, and Belonging in South Asian Waterscapes* — Annual Conference on South Asia, Madison, upcoming October 2026.
- *Sanitary Futures: Disease, Railways, and the Politics of Improvement in Colonial Delhi, 1857–1900*. Panel: Engineering Environment — Yale University, February 2026.
- *Imperial Indian Capital: Constructing New Delhi Amid Its Unhealthiness, 1911–1932*. New Perspectives on India's Environmental History — ASEH, March 2026.
- *Imperial Indian Capital: Constructing New Delhi Amid Its Unhealthiness, 1911–1932*. Graduate Research Meet, IIT Guwahati, January 2026.
- *Lively Waters in South Asia: Agency, Ethics, and Politics*. Roundtable, Annual Conference on South Asia, University of Wisconsin–Madison, 2022 — organized and presented with Calynn Dowler, Oviya Govindan, et al.
- Association for Asian Studies Annual Conference — attended and networked, 2023.

FELLOWSHIPS AND GRANTS

- **2026–27** — CISS Dissertation Finishing Fellowship, Boston University Center for Innovation in Social Science.
- **2026** — Summer Mini-Grant, Boston University Center for Innovation in Social Science.
- **2026** — Research Fellowship, Spring Semester, Boston University.
- **2026** — ASEH Travel Grant.
- **2025** — Research Fellowship, Fall Semester, Boston University.
- **2025** — Laura Bassi Foundation Editorial Support.
- **2024** — Long-Term Graduate Research in the United States Fellowship, Boston University; supported research at the University of Chicago, the National Archives in Washington, DC, and the Rockefeller Library in New York.
- **2024** — Long-Term Graduate Research Abroad Fellowship, Boston University; supported archival research at the National Archives of India, the British Library in London, and the University of Edinburgh.
- **2023** — Summer Research Grant, Dept. of History, Boston University; funded primary research at the National Archives of India and the Delhi Archives.
- **2023** — BU Department Travel Grant; supported a research presentation at the Annual Conference on South Asia, University of Wisconsin–Madison.
- **2022** — Summer Research Grant, Dept. of History, Boston University; funded primary research on rivers and development in Delhi, Lucknow, and Gujarat.
- **2021** — Dean's Fellowship, Graduate School of Arts and Sciences, Boston University; a university-wide fellowship awarded at the start of doctoral study.

LANGUAGES

English (reading, writing, speaking) · Hindi (reading, writing, speaking) · Urdu (reading)